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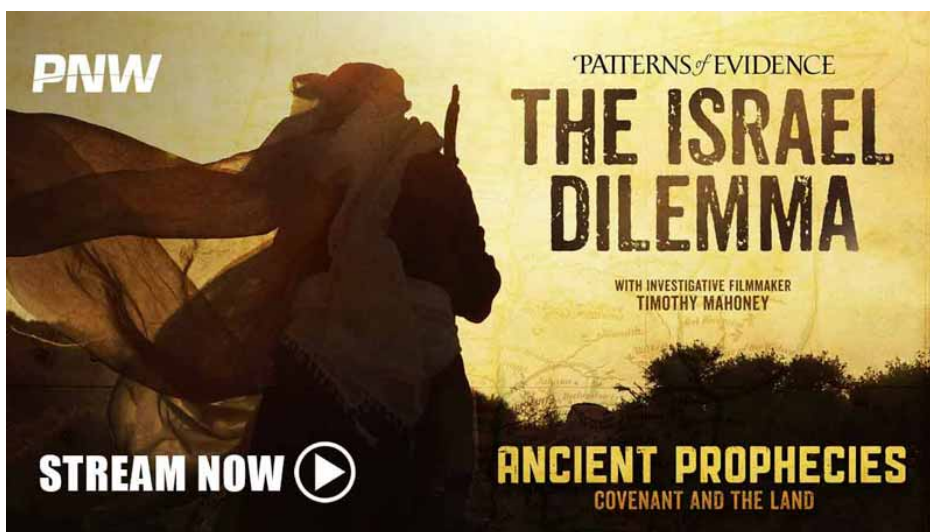
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ARTICLE

Number Of Single Men In U.S. Reaches Record High





BY DAN HART/WASHINGTON STAND SEPTEMBER 14, 2026

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More young men in America are remaining single than ever before, with the rate almost doubling over the last quarter century, according to concerning new data released earlier this week.

Statistics compiled by the Institute for Family Studies (IFS) revealed that there were 30.4 million single men aged 18 to 39 in 2025 in the U.S., amounting to almost 10 million more bachelors than there were in 2000 (20.7 million). IFS further estimated that there were 15 million more single men than husbands in this age group in 2025. In 2000, there was only a 2.6 million difference.

This rise in male singleness has translated to fewer married men. Over the last 25 years, the number of wedded men has plunged from 18.1 million to 15.4 million, a 15% drop.

Experts say the sinking numbers are extremely troubling for the future prospects of the country in a host of ways. Sociologists like IFS Fellow Brad Wilcox point out that single men are "more likely to be lonely, prone to deaths of despair and unhappy," adding that "it's never good for a society to have large numbers of unattached, dispirited and unhappy young men." Data shows that unhappiness is rising among single men, from 16% in 1980 to 23% in 2020. Comparatively, the rate of unhappiness among married men has stayed steady, hovering between 8-7% over the same time span.



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A large part of this is likely due to the fact that the number of men attending college and remaining in the job force are dropping. Data from 2024 showed that one million fewer men were in college compared to 2011. As for employment, Gen Z men aged 16-24 are particularly exiting the labor market, with data from July showing a 13% drop compared to numbers from 2000. This has led to many young men being less likely to attract a spouse through stable employment, owning a car, and other signs of financial steadiness.



High rates of male unemployment are closely tied to the decline in recent years of high-paying blue-collar jobs in the manufacturing sector, which are traditionally dominated by men. Over the last four years, job openings in manufacturing have nosedived, causing many men to settle for low-paying gig jobs or exit the workforce altogether.

Donna Turner, an educational psychologist in Indiana, told The Washington Times that economic instability is "playing a major role" in why so many men are remaining single. "When wages are unstable, and housing feels out of reach, many men feel they cannot qualify as husbands. Women are understandably reluctant to tie their futures to economic precarity."

Economists say that a significant factor in seeing a revival in marriage and birth rates will depend on working-class men recovering financial stability. This can be encouraged through more public investment in skilled trades, experts say. "Not every young man needs to go for a four-year college degree," Siri Terjesen, an associate business dean at Florida Atlantic University, emphasized. "America can make investments in apprenticeship and skilled trades programs that will lead to good economic outcomes."

Another crucial factor in rejuvenating marriage among young men will also likely hinge on their increasing religiosity in recent years. In April, Gallup reported a sharp rise in men aged 18-29 who reported that religion was "very important" to them, climbing from 28% in 2022 to 42% in 2025. Data shows that religious men marry at higher rates than non-religious men.



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Still, experts like David Closson, who serves as director of the Center for Biblical Worldview at Family Research Council, say that a turnaround in the prospects for men will depend on deep cultural renewal centered on biblical principles.

"At the deepest level, the rise in single men reflects a culture that has rejected God's design for marriage, sex, and family," he told The Washington Stand. "Scripture presents marriage as a good gift from God and calls men to mature into sacrificial responsibility, becoming the kind of husbands who love, provide for, and lead their families faithfully. Our culture has increasingly detached sex from covenant, delayed adulthood, and taught men to prioritize autonomy over obligation, all of which work against marriage."

Closson added that churches will serve a central role in renewing a culture of marriage and discipling single men. "The most important thing churches can do is recover a robust biblical vision of manhood and marriage and intentionally disciple young men toward holiness, courage, work, self-denial, and readiness for family life. Churches should not idolize marriage, but they should once again speak clearly about it as a normative and deeply good calling for most Christians."

Originally published at The Washington Stand (<https://washingtonstand.com/article/number-of-single-men-in-us-reaches-record-high>)

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